

POKER RUSH

Game Design Document v0.1

PART 1 — PITCH SUMMARY

The One-Liner

Poker Rush is a real-time multiplayer racing game where your poker hands control your speed — the better you play, the faster you drive.

Concept Overview

Poker Rush fuses two genres that have never been combined at speed: **video poker** and **arcade racing**. Players compete head-to-head in 3–5 minute races where they are playing rapid-fire video poker hands simultaneously. Every hand outcome directly translates into acceleration or deceleration on the track. Win big at the table, pull ahead on the track. Go cold, fall behind.

The result is a game that rewards **skill**, **risk management**, and **clutch decision-making** — and creates a spectator-friendly experience where the race is always in doubt until the very last hand.

The Core Loop

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Play a poker hand → Earn/lose speed points → Watch your car move on the track  
→ Decide whether to double down for more speed → Race ends → Collect rewards  
→ Buy power-ups → Enter next race
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Why It Works

Tension	Source
Poker tension	Am I making the optimal hold? Will the draw pay off?
Race tension	Am I gaining or losing ground on my opponents?
Risk tension	Do I double down for more speed, or cash out safely?
Meta tension	Do I use my power-up now or save it?

Each layer of tension reinforces the others. A player trailing in the race is incentivized to take bigger poker risks. A player in the lead has something to protect. This creates **come-from-behind moments** and

dramatic collapses that make every race a story.

Target Audience

- Casual to mid-core players who enjoy card games and competitive multiplayer
 - Video poker fans looking for a social, competitive angle
 - Racing game fans who want a fresh twist on the genre
 - Ages 18+ (gambling-themed mechanics)
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Platform & Format

- PC (primary), Mobile (secondary)
 - Free-to-play with cosmetic monetization and chip purchases
 - Multiplayer-first (2–6 players per race), with solo practice mode
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Key Differentiators

1. **No equivalent exists** — the poker-racing hybrid genre is wide open
 2. **Spectator-friendly** — watching the race unfold while knowing the poker context is compelling
 3. **High replayability** — 8 poker variants, configurable race settings, rotating power-up meta
 4. **Social hooks** — live betting on races you're not in, leaderboards, reputation system
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PART 2 — FULL GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

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1. Game Overview

Genre

Multiplayer Arcade Racing / Video Poker Hybrid

Core Premise

2–6 players race simultaneously on a looping track. Each player controls their own vehicle, but vehicle speed is determined entirely by the results of rapid-fire video poker hands played in real time. Races last 3–5 minutes, with a "final lap" triggered at time expiry.

Pillars

- **Speed of play** — Hands resolve fast. No waiting. Action is constant.
 - **Meaningful decisions** — Every hold, every double-down, every power-up activation matters.
 - **Social competition** — Win money, rep, and bragging rights. Lose and feel it.
 - **Accessible depth** — Easy to jump in, hard to master.
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2. Screen Flow & Navigation

2.1 Welcome / Main Menu Screen

The entry point of the game. From here, players can:

Action	Description
Quick Play	Immediately enter matchmaking queue using their saved racing profile preferences
Play	Navigate to the Game Mode Selection screen to choose poker variant and configure a race
Matchmaking Room	Browse, create, join, or bet on upcoming races
Profile	View and edit profile, stats, and power-up loadout
Leaderboard	View the top 20 global players by reputation points

2.2 Game Mode Selection Screen

Players select their preferred poker variant before entering a race. Options:

- Triple Double Bonus Poker
- All American
- Loose Deuces
- Bonus Draw Poker
- Double Joker Poker
- Double Bonus Draw Poker
- Double Double Draw Poker
- Triple Double Draw Poker

After selecting, the player is entered into matchmaking for a race using that variant (or joins the race they were creating).

2.3 Matchmaking Room

A social hub screen listing upcoming and in-progress races. See Section 9 for full detail.

2.4 Race Screen

The primary gameplay screen. See Section 13 for full UI layout detail.

3. Player Profile & Progression

3.1 Profile Fields

Field	Description
Username	Display name shown to all players
Default Poker Variant	Pre-selected game type for Quick Play
Avatar / Vehicle Skin	Visual customization (cosmetic)
Racing Profile	Default race preferences for matchmaking queue (player count, power-ups on/off, skill level)

3.2 Stats Tracked

Poker Stats:

- Hands played
- Win rate by hand type
- Total chips won / lost
- Favorite variant

Racing Stats:

- Races entered / won / lost
- Win rate by player count
- Average finishing position
- Best streak

3.3 Starting Conditions

- New players receive a **10,000 chip bankroll** upon registration.
- Players who run out of chips have three options:

1. **Purchase chips** (real-money or in-game purchase) 2. **Claim daily chip drop** (free replenishment on a 24-hour cooldown) 3. **Profile reset** — wipes all stats and rep, restores 10k chip bankroll

4. Poker Gameplay

4.1 Format

Each player plays an independent video poker session on their own client. All players use the same poker variant for the duration of a race (set by the race creator or assigned randomly).

Hands are dealt and resolved as fast as the player can act — there is no forced timer per hand, but the race clock is always ticking, incentivizing fast play.

4.2 Supported Variants

All 8 variants use standard video poker rules for their respective type. Pay tables follow industry-standard configurations for each variant:

Variant	Key Feature
Triple Double Bonus Poker	High premium on 4-of-a-kind hands with kicker bonuses
All American	Elevated pay on straights, flushes, and straight flushes
Loose Deuces	All 2s are wild; aggressive pay table
Bonus Draw Poker	Bonus pay on 4 Aces
Double Joker Poker	2 jokers wild; natural royal flush pays premium
Double Bonus Draw Poker	Bonus payouts on all 4-of-a-kind hands
Double Double Draw Poker	Additional kicker bonus on top of Double Bonus pay table
Triple Double Draw Poker	Further escalated 4-of-a-kind bonuses

4.3 Chip Wagering

Each hand requires a chip wager. Standard bet is 1 unit (configurable). Chips won/lost per hand follow the poker variant's pay table multiplied by bet amount. The chip economy runs in parallel to, and independently from, the speed point system.

5. Race Mechanics

5.1 Track & Vehicles

- Races take place on a looping circuit with a configurable visual theme (set by race creator).
- Each player controls one vehicle. Vehicle position on track is calculated from accumulated speed points in real time.
- Vehicles are purely cosmetic — performance is driven entirely by poker results and power-ups.

5.2 Race Duration

- Minimum: **3 minutes**
- Maximum: **5 minutes**
- At time expiry, a **Final Lap** is triggered. The race ends when the leading car completes one additional full lap. All cars finish after the leader.

5.3 Skill Levels

Races can be filtered by skill level to ensure fair competition:

Level	Description
Newbie	Recommended for new players; lower entry-level poker variant difficulty
Advanced	Mid-tier; standard competition
Pro	High-level players; no restrictions on aggressive play styles

5.4 Player Count

- Minimum: **2 players**
- Maximum: **6 players**

6. Speed Point System

6.1 Base Rules

Every hand result generates a speed modifier applied to the player's vehicle:

Outcome	Speed Change
Any loss	−3% speed
Pair	+1 point → +2% speed
Two Pair	+2 points → +4% speed
Three of a Kind	+3 points → +6% speed
Straight	+4 points → +8% speed
Flush	+5 points → +10% speed
Full House	+6 points → +12% speed
Four of a Kind	+7 points → +14% speed

Outcome	Speed Change
Straight Flush	+8 points → +16% speed
Royal Flush	+10 points → +20% speed

Formula: each speed point = +2% speed modifier applied cumulatively over the race.

6.2 Speed Calculation

Speed is calculated as a running cumulative modifier from race start. Speed cannot go below a minimum floor (preventing vehicles from stopping entirely) and has a soft cap at maximum speed to prevent runaway leaders.

Design note: The exact floor and ceiling values are tuning parameters. Suggested starting values: floor = 30% of base speed, ceiling = 200% of base speed.

7. Double Down System

The Double Down system introduces a risk/reward decision after every hand, creating micro-moments of drama.

7.1 After a Winning Hand — Boost Mode

After any winning hand, the player is prompted to guess: **Red or Black** (next card drawn from a fresh deck).

Result	Outcome
Correct guess	Speed points for that hand are doubled
Incorrect guess	Speed points for that hand are lost (treated as 0, not a loss)

Players may double down **up to 3 times** on a single winning hand:

- After guess 1: Cash out or double again
- After guess 2: Cash out or double again (final)
- After guess 3: Automatic cash out with tripled base points

7.2 After a Losing Hand — Mitigation Mode

After any losing hand, the player may attempt to reduce the penalty. One guess only.

Result	Speed Change
Correct guess	Loss penalty reduced by 50% (–1.5% instead of –3%)
Incorrect guess	Loss penalty increased to –4.5%

This forces meaningful risk assessment even on bad hands — sometimes it's better to absorb the –3% than risk –4.5%.

8. Power-Up System

8.1 Overview

Power-ups provide temporary in-race advantages. They are purchased with chips between races and equipped before a race starts (up to 3 active slots).

8.2 Acquiring Power-Ups

Source	Method
Chip Store	Direct purchase between races
Raffle Tickets	Earned by finishing in top positions; tickets enter a draw for rare power-ups

8.3 Equipping Power-Ups

- Players have **3 power-up slots**.
- Power-ups are equipped from the Profile screen or the Matchmaking Room.
- Each power-up may only be used **once per race**.

8.4 Activation

During a race, the Power-Up Panel is visible on the right side of the race display. Each slot has an **Activate** button. Power-ups can be toggled on/off per race (set by race creator — either all players have power-ups enabled, or none do).

8.5 Power-Up Design Space (Examples)

Specific power-ups to be defined in a follow-up balance pass. Below are illustrative concepts:

Power-Up	Effect
Nitro Burst	Instant +15% speed for 20 seconds
Speed Lock	Freeze your current speed for 15 seconds (immune to loss penalties)
Sabotage	Apply a one-time –5% speed hit to a targeted opponent
Double Points	Next winning hand gives 2× speed points
Safety Net	Negate the next losing hand's speed penalty entirely
Comeback Engine	Grants +10% speed if currently in last place

9. Matchmaking & Race Creation

9.1 Matchmaking Room Overview

A lobby-style screen where players can create races, browse available races, join races, or spectate/bet on upcoming races.

9.2 Creating a Race

Race creators configure:

Setting	Options
Poker Game Type	Select specific variant, or "Default" / "Random"
Number of Racers	2 to 6 players
Power-Ups	Enabled or Disabled
Race Duration	3 to 5 minutes
Race Visual	Choose track/environment theme
Skill Level	Newbie / Advanced / Pro
Start Time	Schedule a future time, or "Now" (fills from random queue)

If any field is left blank, the system assigns a random valid value.

A **Schedule / Start** button finalizes the race creation. The race becomes visible in the Matchmaking Room list.

9.3 Quick Play

From the main menu, Quick Play immediately enters the player into the matchmaking queue using their saved **racing profile defaults** (preferred player count, power-ups preference, skill level). The system assigns them to the best available match.

9.4 Matchmaking Queue Logic

To be defined during technical design. Suggested approach: ELO-adjacent rep-based matching within skill level brackets, with fallback to open matching if queue wait exceeds 60 seconds.

10. Betting System

10.1 Pre-Race Betting

Before a race begins, **any player in the Matchmaking Room** (including players not participating in the race) may place bets on the outcome.

10.2 Bet Types

Bet Type	Description
1st Place	Pick the race winner
1st + 2nd Place	Correctly pick both top finishers (order matters)
1st + 2nd + 3rd Place	Correctly pick the top 3 (order matters)

Available bet types scale with race player count:

Race Size	Available Bet Types
2 players	1st place only
3 players	1st place only
4 players	1st place, 1st+2nd
5 players	1st place, 1st+2nd, 1st+2nd+3rd
6 players	1st place, 1st+2nd, 1st+2nd+3rd

10.3 Bet Payouts

Payouts are added on top of race rewards for participants, and paid directly to non-participating bettors. Payout odds are determined by the system at race start based on player rep/skill levels.

Exact payout calculation (fixed odds vs. parimutuel) to be defined in economy design pass.

11. Rewards & Economy

11.1 Race Finish Rewards

Rewards are distributed based on finishing position and race size:

2-Player Race

Place	Rep	Chips	Raffle Tickets
1st	+100	+25,000	1
2nd	−50	0	0

3-Player Race

Place	Rep	Chips	Raffle Tickets
1st	+125	+40,000	1
2nd	+25	+5,000	0
3rd	−50	0	0

4-Player Race

Place	Rep	Chips	Raffle Tickets
1st	+150	+50,000	1
2nd	+25	+10,000	0
3rd	+10	+2,000	0
4th	−50	0	0

5-Player Race

Place	Rep	Chips	Raffle Tickets
1st	+175	+60,000	2
2nd	+75	+15,000	1
3rd	+15	+5,000	0

Place	Rep	Chips	Raffle Tickets
4th	0	0	0
5th	−50	0	0

6-Player Race

Place	Rep	Chips	Raffle Tickets
1st	+200	+75,000	3
2nd	+100	+25,000	2
3rd	+50	+10,000	1
4th	+10	0	0
5th	−25	0	0
6th	−50	0	0

All chip and rep amounts are in addition to any race bet winnings.

11.2 Economy Overview

Currency	Earned By	Spent On
Chips	Race prizes, poker winnings, daily drop, purchase	Power-ups, chip bets, larger poker wagers
Rep Points	Race finishes	Not spent — progression/ranking metric only
Raffle Tickets	Top race finishes	Entered into power-up draws

12. Leaderboard & Reputation

12.1 Global Leaderboard

Displays the **top 20 players** ranked by total Reputation Points. Visible from the main menu.

12.2 Reputation Design Notes

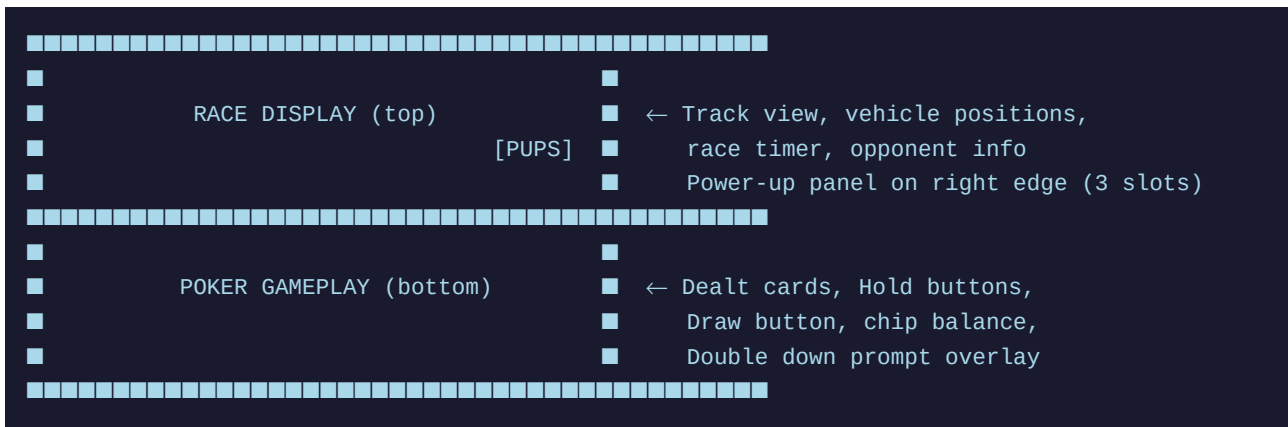
Rep is zero-sum within each race (net positive for top finishers, negative for bottom). This keeps the leaderboard competitive over time — you cannot simply grind rep by playing safe. You must race and finish well.

Consider season resets (monthly/quarterly) to keep the leaderboard accessible and competitive for newer players.

13. UI/UX Layout

13.1 Race Screen Layout

The race screen uses a **vertical split** design:



13.2 Race Display Panel (Top)

- Live track showing all player vehicles with name labels
- Race timer (counting down to Final Lap trigger)
- Player speed delta indicators (who is accelerating / decelerating)
- Current standings (position 1 through N)
- Power-Up Panel — 3 slots with individual Activate buttons, visible at all times

13.3 Poker Panel (Bottom)

- Card display (5 cards, face up after deal)
- Hold / Unhold buttons beneath each card
- Draw button
- Current chip balance and current hand wager
- Double Down overlay — appears after hand resolution (Red / Black choice, Cash Out option)
- Last hand result indicator (win type + speed change applied)

13.4 Matchmaking Room Layout

- Left panel: Race list (browsable, sortable by start time / player count / skill level)
- Right panel: Race detail view + Bet placement panel
- Bottom bar: Create Race button, Enter Matchmaking button, Back button

- Profile quick-edit accessible via header
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14. Open Design Questions

The following items require further design or balancing work before production:

1. **Speed floor / ceiling values** — Prevent runaway leaders and stalled trailers
 2. **Power-up catalogue** — Full list with names, costs, cooldowns, and balance pass
 3. **Poker chip bet sizing** — Default wager and min/max wager per hand
 4. **Matchmaking algorithm** — Rep-based brackets, timeout fallbacks
 5. **Betting payout model** — Fixed odds vs. parimutuel pool
 6. **Season reset cadence** — Leaderboard freshness vs. long-term progression
 7. **Daily chip drop amount** — Generosity vs. chip economy health
 8. **Mobile UI adaptation** — Split-screen layout needs redesign for portrait/landscape on small screens
 9. **Anti-cheat / speed hacking** — Server-authoritative speed calculation required for multiplayer integrity
 10. **Solo / Practice mode** — Onboarding experience for new players before entering live races
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Document version 0.1 — April 2026 Game title "Poker Rush" is a working title and subject to change.